trip to stay with the Boyds about three hours,

but we weren't there to visit but to have me practice driving, and that practice I had. Despite all my driving lessons, it was only when I returned from the Boyds that I felt I could drive. 5

After that, I returned the car to the dealer to hold it for me for the rest of the month because I was going to the Breadloaf Writers Conference and didn't yet dare to drive there.

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The Breadloaf Writers Conference was held in conjunction with Middlebury College, in Middlebury, Vermont. It was the oldest and most prestigious of the writers' conferences and was held every year in the last half of August.

It was run at that time by Theodore Morrison of Harvard, but among the important men of the faculty was Fletcher Pratt, and it was he who had urged me to attend.

I arrived in Breadloaf on August 16, 1950, without Gertrude, who chose to go to New York and stay with her parents. Pratt was there, of course. Also William Sloane, a publisher who had authored two well-thought-of science-fiction novels, and Catherine Drinker Bowen, a popular historian.

Present in addition was John Ciardi, tall, slim, with a shock of dark hair and an incredibly majestic nose that would have made it possible for him play Cyrano without makeup. He had a beautiful bass voice that was delightful to listen to. He was a poet and when he lectured on poetry there was no use in his trying to distinguish between good poetry and bad poetry. When he read poetry, it all sounded good.

The bookstore contained copies of books by the various faculty members, and that meant it contained copies of Pebble in the Sky.

It was at Breadloaf, I think (though just possibly at Annisquam, three weeks earlier), that someone came to me, shook my hand vigorously, and said, "Congratulations."

"On what?" I said.

"On keeping your name. It takes courage to insist on being called Tsaac'"